

While You Read

-  **5 Reading** Look at the first two paragraphs of the article in 6. Use the context to explain the meaning of the underlined words.
-  **6 Reading again** Look at the article. Compare your ideas to the problems and solutions you discussed in 3 to the information in the article.

A City That's Doing Something Right

A There's good news and bad news about life in modern cities – first, the bad. People who study population growth predict a nightmare by the year 2025: the global population will be more than eight billion, and almost four billion of these people will be living in cities in developing countries such as India and Nigeria. Population growth is already causing serious problems in many cities such as air pollution, disease, and crime. People spend hours in traffic when they travel daily from their homes to their work and back. There isn't enough water, transportation, or houses for people to live in. Many people don't have access to health services or jobs. Now the good news: in *some* cities, such as Berlin, Dubai, and Vancouver, instead of worsening, urban life is actually getting much better.

A City and Its Mayor

B It might not be a surprise to find that life in affluent cities is improving. But what about cities that *aren't* rich? The city of Curitiba, Brazil, proves that it's possible for even a city in a developing country to offer a good life to its residents. The former mayor of Curitiba for 25 years, Jaime Lerner, is an architect and a very practical person. Under his leadership, the city planners established a list of priorities – in other words, a list of what was most important to work on. They decided to focus on the environment and on the quality of life. With an average income of only about \$2,000 per person per year, Curitiba has the same problems as many cities. However, it also has some creative solutions.

Garbage Collection

C One creative solution is how they collect garbage – *Cambio Verde*, or Green Exchange. This does far more than clean the streets of trash. In neighborhoods that garbage trucks can't reach, poor people bring bags of trash to special centers. At these centers, they exchange the trash for fresh produce such as potatoes and oranges. They receive one kilo of produce for every four kilos of trash that they bring in. At a recycling plant, workers separate glass bottles, plastic, and cans from other trash. *Two-thirds* of Curitiba's garbage is recycled, which is good for the environment. And the plant gives jobs to the poorest people, which improves their lives.

Transportation

D Due to careful planning, Curitiba does not have the same traffic problems that most cities have. The statistics are surprising. The population has grown fast, to over two million people, but traffic has actually decreased 30 percent. Curitiba couldn't afford an expensive subway so instead there's an unusual system of buses



in the center lanes of five wide major streets. At each bus stop, there is a glass tube that's 40 feet long. Passengers pay before they enter the tube. Then they get on the bus "subway style" – through wide doors. This allows people to get on and off the bus quickly and efficiently. People get on and off the bus in only 30 seconds. This makes traveling around the city more pleasant and also helps to solve the problem of air pollution.

A Creative Social Program

- E** There is an agricultural operation just outside Curitiba that looks like other farms but actually helps to solve a social problem, in addition to growing crops. At *Fazenda da Solidaridade* (Solidarity Farm), the workers are not experienced farmers. Instead, they are people with mental and psychological challenges who volunteer to spend up to nine months in a program called *Verde Saude* (Green Health). The program helps them in two ways. First, it gives them jobs. They cultivate medicinal plants and then process them into herbal teas, syrups, and other products that are sold in health-food stores. Second, it offers them counseling, medical care, and job training.

The Environment

- F** To make the environment both cleaner and more beautiful, Curitiba encourages green space. It has low taxes for companies that have green areas. Several hundred major industries such as Pepsi and Volvo, which are willing to have green space in their plants, have offices in the city taking advantage of the city's low tax rate. Bringing natural beauty into the city is a priority. For this reason, Curitiba gave 1.5 million young trees to neighborhoods to plant and take care of. And the downtown shopping area is now a pedestrian zone – in other words, for walkers only, not cars – and is lined with gardens. Curitiba provides the city people with 22 million square meters of parks and green areas – more than three times the amount that the World Health Organization recommends for cities.



A Symbol of the Possible

- G** Clearly, too many people choosing to live in big cities worldwide is the cause of serious problems. However, the example of Curitiba provides hope that careful planning and creative thinking can lead to solutions. Many other cities worldwide are following Curitiba's lead and aim to reduce their carbon footprint. For example, city planners in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, have updated their pipework to prevent leaks and in Copenhagen, Denmark, there is now a system in place where 50 percent of trash is burned to create heat. Curitiba is truly, as Lewis Mumford once said of cities in general, a "symbol of the possible."